Shortly after this, Akbar suffered a more serious reverse. He had spent the day leading an attack on the city, and in the evening had retired to the camp to welcome a new group of Khajrani tribal levies who had just appeared to offer their services. After welcoming the new arrivals, according to the reports forwarded to the British by a sympathetic Afghan chieftain,

> Sardar Akbar Khan who had not eaten during the day stood up and moved a few paces to one side to eat his dinner which had been brought to him, and to look on while the Khajranis made their approach to attack the defences of Jalalabad. While standing he received a serious wound from a double barrelled gun which struck him on the fleshy part of the arm and passed through his breast. Two men were seized and charged with having done this act. One of them had previously been Shah [Shuja's] Pishkhidmat [table servant]. They pleaded that the gun had gone off by accident. The Sirdar is confined to his seat and no one but [his father-in-law] Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai is allowed to go near him; his troops are much dispirited.[46]

Afghan sources all assume that the shooting was an attempted assassination. Mirza 'Ata reported rumours that the British were behind it. 'General Sale was using all means to oust the Sardar from his position, to no effect,' he wrote. 'So at last he managed to have one of the Sardar's trusted personal attendants offered two lakh (200,000 Rupees) to murder him. The wretch sold his faith and honour and accepted the money, and waited for an opportunity to shoot the Sardar. Even though the shot wounded Akbar Khan in the shoulder, God was protecting the Ghazi, and he did not die.'[47]

Most observers, however, blamed the Sadozais. According to Fayz Mohammad,

> some of those present immediately grabbed the ingrate responsible and after dressing Akbar's wound they brought the servant before the wounded Sardar who reproached him and demanded an explanation. The man expressed repentance, kissed the ground, and produced a letter from Shah Shuja offering Rs 50,000 for the assassination. He revealed that the Shah and the English had given him 25,000 rupees up front, and the promise of another 25,000 after the job was done. The Sardar kept Shah Shuja's letter and, since the man had spoken truthfully, forgave him. But the ghazis summoned him and another man who was a co-conspirator and killed them both.[48]

This seems to have been the case: according to the report that reached the hostages from their jailers, the would-be assassin was 'roasted alive for his crime'.[49]